

TO: MWR Director / Division Leadership

FROM: Tyson Bruce, Golf Course Superintendent – Veterans Memorial Golf Course

DATE: May 2026

SUBJ: Golf Course Master Plan – What's Been Done, What's In Progress, and What Needs to Happen

VETERANS MEMORIAL GOLF COURSE — MASTER PLAN

Naval Station Great Lakes, Illinois

OVERVIEW

I've been here about six weeks. When I got here the daily operation was barely functional — most of the mowing equipment was out of service, the irrigation system was shut off, the asset inventory hadn't been touched, and nobody had walked the course systematically in a while. I started from scratch.

What's been done:

Walked all 18 holes and documented 103 open course issues in the management system. Got the FY26 asset inventory started — 211 items across two sites. Submitted 10 purchase requests totaling \$24,971.73 to address critical gaps. Six of those are fully received: the rough mower is running on new tires, the crew has safety gear and supplies, seed and divot mix for the ~~fall renovation are on hand~~, and a rental tractor is currently on-site mowing rough and fairways since the own mowing fleet is mostly out of service. Four more purchase requests are approved and in transit — mower rebuild parts, a greens sprayer, fertilizer, and moss treatment.

What's being done right now:

Equipment repairs are in progress. Greens mower rebuild parts are in transit — once they arrive the mechanic gets those units running. The irrigation vendor (Clesen's) has a proposal approved and is ready to schedule as soon as the NAVFAC water line connection is finished and funding is released. Moss and grub treatments start the day the fertilizer and Quicksilver arrive.

remove grub treatments and say the quicksilver will treat the moss as soon as i receive my applicators license

What needs to happen:

NAVFAC has to finish the water line connection so the course can actually be watered. Leadership needs to ~~release the irrigation repair funding~~. The laborer vacancy problem needs a real solution — we're at 4 of 8 authorized positions and the pay isn't competitive enough to fix that without a policy-level decision. Disposal of

22 old assets needs to be formally initiated. Fall aeration, overseeding, and the back nine greens renovation need to be planned and budgeted now, not in August.

The rest of this document covers the specifics — hole-by-hole conditions, equipment status, purchase request details, asset inventory, and a timeline.

SECTION 1 — STAFFING SITUATION

Authorized vs. Actual

The maintenance department is authorized the following positions:

Position	Authorized	Currently Filled
Mechanic	1	1
Laborers (seasonal)	8	4
Total	9	5

We are operating at 55% of authorized maintenance strength during the summer season. The four open laborer positions cannot be filled because NAF wages are not competitive with what private and municipal golf courses in the surrounding area pay. Candidates apply, see the pay rate, and take jobs elsewhere. This is not a local management problem. It is a compensation structure problem that requires a policy-level solution.

Mechanic Capability Gap

The one mechanic we have is capable and productive. He handles tires, batteries, fuel lines, filters, belts, and standard mechanical work on gas-powered equipment. However, a significant portion of the maintenance fleet is diesel-powered. When diesel equipment breaks down, it requires outside vendor service. That process is slow, expensive, and means equipment sits idle waiting on quotes and scheduling. Every week a mower is down waiting on a diesel repair is a week it is not maintaining the course.



SECTION 2 — DOCUMENTED COURSE CONDITIONS

103 Open Issues Across All 18 Holes

As of May 2026, the course management system shows **103 open issues** logged across every hole on the course. None have been resolved. Every issue is categorized, mapped by location, and documented with a description.



Issue breakdown by category:

Category	Count	Holes Affected
Tee box — needs aeration and overseeding	16	2, 3, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18
Thin turf	17	1, 4, 6, 8, 11, 14, 15, 17, 18
Bare spots	9	8, 9, 10, 15, 16, 18
Grub / pest damage	12	3, 6, 8, 10, 15, 18
Mulch piles (debris)	11	3, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 14, 18
Sticks on ground (debris)	10	2, 7, 10, 11, 12, 14, 15, 17, 18
Weed pressure	6	9, 13, 17
Felled / damaged trees	7	4, 11, 12, 15, 17
Drainage issues	2	14, 17
Wet area	1	7
Irrigation issue (mapped)	1	13
TOTAL	103	All 18 holes

What These Mean

Tee boxes: Sixteen of eighteen tee boxes are documented as needing aeration and overseeding. Every patron who plays this course steps onto a worn, compacted tee surface on virtually every hole. This is the first physical contact they have with each hole and it immediately communicates that the course is not being maintained.

Thin turf and bare spots: Thin turf appears on nine holes; bare spots on six. This is not isolated — it is spread across the entire back nine and large portions of the front. The contributing factors are compaction from lack of aeration, active grub populations, and the inability to water consistently because the irrigation system is not functional.

Grub damage: Active grub populations are documented on holes 3, 6, 8, 10, 15, and 18. Grubs feed on root systems and will continue to expand without a targeted treatment program. Spring is the most effective treatment window. Quicksilver herbicide and starter fertilizer have been ordered (PR#17 — approved, pending delivery) to begin addressing this alongside the moss problem on the back nine. Missing this window means a significantly larger problem by midsummer.



Debris and uncleared trees: Three holes (4, 11, 12) have felled trees that are still on the course. There are 11 documented mulch pile issues and 10 sticks-on-ground issues across the back nine and late front nine. These exist because with 4 laborers instead of 8, the crew has no bandwidth beyond the essential daily maintenance tasks.



Drainage — Holes 14 and 17: Two holes have documented drainage problems. Hole 7 has a standing wet area. These are not new conditions and are connected to the same root cause as the back nine greens moss issue — the course lacks the drainage infrastructure to move water off the turf fast enough.

Back Nine Greens — Moss Infestation

The back nine greens are more than half covered in silvery thread moss on the worst greens. This is the result of years of chronic wet conditions caused by inadequate drainage. Moss does not respond to surface treatment without fixing the drainage first — any chemical application that kills existing moss will be re-colonized if the wet conditions that caused it persist.

The treatment plan, already initiated with an approved purchase order for Quicksilver herbicide (PR#17), is:

1. Apply Quicksilver herbicide to eliminate existing moss coverage
2. Core aerate and remove infested organic matter 
3. Correct drainage to address the root cause 
4. Backfill, level, and reseed with creeping bentgrass 

Creeping bentgrass seed has already been received (PR#9 — 5 buckets of PureFormance blend, received). Starter fertilizer 13-25-12 is approved and on order (PR#17). Green sand/peat mix for the renovation has been received (PR#9). The renovation inputs are largely on hand or approved. The execution window is late August through early September — the agronomic ideal for cool-season establishment in the Great Lakes climate zone. 

SECTION 3 — IRRIGATION SYSTEM

Current Status

The Rainbird irrigation system at Veterans Memorial Golf Course has two separate failures that together make coordinated watering impossible:

Failure 1 — Water source. The water supply line to the course was shut off at the pump house level. NAVFAC was formally requested several weeks ago to restore water flow. They have turned on water to portions of the system, but a missing pipe section that connects the pump houses to the underground irrigation distribution line has not been installed. Until that connection is made, water cannot flow to the course regardless of the state of the satellite controllers.

Failure 2 — Satellite controllers. The field satellite controllers that receive commands from the central Rainbird irrigation computer are not communicating with the central system. The vendor, Clesen's (Alex Panzenhagen, Lincolnshire, IL), has assessed the system and submitted a service proposal for diagnosis and repair. 

Approved Purchase Request — Pending Execution

PR#18 — Clesen's Irrigation Service

- Vendor: Clesen's, 635 Margate Drive, Lincolnshire, IL 60069
- Scope: Diagnose and repair Rainbird irrigation system — field and central control communication issues; includes 2 days of on-site service
- Cost: \$2,795.00 (20 hours service @ \$110/hr + 7 hours travel @ \$85/hr)
- Status: **Approved — vendor not yet scheduled, funding not released**
- SOW: Approved

This repair cannot begin until the NAVFAC water line connection is resolved and the funding is released. Both are outside the superintendent's control and require leadership action or coordination.

SECTION 4 — EQUIPMENT STATUS

Mowing Fleet — Critical Failure

The maintenance department's own mowing equipment is largely non-functional. Of all mowers in the equipment system:

Equipment	Status	Notes
Mower Rough Cut	Operational	Only owned mower currently usable
Mower with 60" Deck	Out of Service 	—
Zero Turn Mower	Out of Service	—
Mower Lawn 1997	Out of Service	Flagged for disposal
Mower w/Mulcher	Out of Service	Flagged for disposal
Rotary Flex Mower 	Out of Service	Flagged for disposal
Turf Mower	Out of Service	Flagged for disposal
Mower Rotary Flex Lastec	Out of Service	—
Greens King IV Plus Mower	Out of Service	—
Mower / Greensmaster (×2)	Out of Service	Both flagged for disposal
Fairway Aerator (×2)	Out of Service	—
Aerator	Out of Service	—

Because we cannot maintain rough and fairways on one rough cut mower, a 50-55HP diesel tractor with a 72" rotary cutter was rented through Alta Construction Equipment for a 28-day period. That rental is currently in use and is how the course is being mowed. **This is not a sustainable solution.** The rental costs \$4,738.66 for 28 days. Owning or repairing functional mowing equipment is significantly more cost-effective over any extended period.

Mower rebuild parts — reel assemblies, bedknives, roller rebuild kits, and hardware — have been ordered from Spartan Turf Products (PR#15, approved, pending delivery, \$4,391.68). Once received, the mechanic can rebuild the greens mowing units and restore them to operational status. The long-term fix requires getting those parts in and getting the mowers off the disabled list.

Other Equipment of Note

Equipment	Status
Sprayer 1991	Out of Service — flagged for disposal
Top Dresser with Hopper	Out of Service 
Tractors (1994, 1996, 1998 models)	Out of Service — flagged for disposal 
Trucksters (1995, 1996)	Out of Service — flagged for disposal
Gator (John Deere)	Operational
Tractor Bunker Rake 2010	Operational
Loader Scoop Type	Operational

A dedicated greens sprayer (Greens Wheelie Sprayer, \$2,125) has been ordered through P&W Golf Supply/Wittek (PR#16, approved, pending delivery). This will allow targeted pesticide and moss treatment application on the greens without using the large field sprayer, which is too imprecise for green-level chemical work.

SECTION 5 — FY26 ASSET INVENTORY

Status Summary — 211 Total Items

Status	Count	% of Total
Verified Present	94	44.5%
Unverified	94	44.5%
Needs Disposed	22	10.4%

Status	Count	% of Total
MIA	1	0.5%
Total	211	

Verification is ongoing. The FY26 inventory covers two sites: the Golf Course (7009, 118 items) and the Maintenance Facility (7010, 93 items) 

Missing Asset

Asset #	Description	Book Value
11006241	Electric Pressure Washer	\$697

One item is confirmed missing as of this reporting period. 

22 Items Flagged for Disposal

The following assets are on property but no longer serviceable. Many date to the 1990s. Keeping them on the inventory creates administrative burden and misrepresents the department's actual operational capacity. Formal disposal should be initiated as soon as possible.

Description	Year	Book Value
Ryan Care Machine	1977	\$2,835
Sprayer	1991	\$5,875
Greensmower / 1992	1992	\$3,688
PTO Tiller	—	\$2,100
Mower w/Mulcher	—	\$2,214
Mower Lawn	1997	\$10,877
Greensmaster w/ Rollers & Knife	—	\$14,696
Greensmaster / 2002	2002	\$13,571
Mower / Greensmaster	—	\$10,948
Mower / Greensmaster	—	\$12,287
Rotary Flex Mower	—	\$15,000
Turf Mower	—	\$26,816
P/U Truck	2002	\$26,659

Description	Year	Book Value
Truckster	1995	\$8,398
Truckster	1996	\$8,616
Tractor	1996	\$13,841
Tractor	—	\$9,449
Tractor / 1998	1998	\$15,795
Tractor/Loader	1994	\$10,947
Tractor Spreader	—	\$1,300
Golf Cart / 2000	2000	\$3,563
Golf Cart (additional)	—	\$2,861

Total book value of disposal items: approximately \$191,336

SECTION 6 — PURCHASE REQUESTS: WHAT HAS BEEN ORDERED AND WHY

Received — Work Already in Progress

The following purchase requests have been approved and materials received. This represents the immediate operational stabilization work that has already begun.

R#	Vendor	Description	Amount	Justification
	NAPA Auto Parts	Safety equipment, maintenance supplies, trimmer line, shop materials	\$613.56	Basic operational supplies the department did not have
	Alta Construction Equipment	50-55HP tractor + 72" rotary cutter — 28-day rental via Contracting Office	\$4,738.66	Mower rental while own equipment is under repair — currently in active use
	R&R Products	Roller bearings, ponchos, ear muffs, 2-stroke oil, bar/chain oil	\$383.75	Safety gear and small equipment fluids
	R&R Products	Tires (×4) for rough mower — 20x10.00-10 Carlisle Turf Saver	\$435.80	Rough mower was inoperable on flat tires

PR#	Vendor	Description	Amount	Justification
	ULINE	Cleaning supplies — paper towels, dish soap, dry erase markers	\$301.50	Facility cleaning materials
	Clesen's	Kentucky Bluegrass blend (×15 bags), Creeping Bentgrass seed (×5 buckets), Green sand/peat mix (1 tote)	\$3,931.41	Seed and divot mix for tees, fairways, and greens renovation
		Total Received	\$10,404.68	

Approved — Pending Delivery or Execution

The following have been approved and are awaiting delivery or vendor scheduling.

PR#	Vendor	Description	Amount	Status
5	Spartan Turf Products	Greens mower reel assemblies (×6), bedknives (×12), roller rebuild kits (×24), hardware	\$4,391.68	Approved — in transit
6	P&W Golf / Wittek	Greens Wheelie Sprayer, horizontal range yardage markers (Bulls Eye Red)	\$2,843.48	Approved — in transit
7	Clesen's	Starter fertilizer 13-25-12 (×20 bags), maintenance fert 12-24-8 (×25 bags), Quicksilver moss herbicide (×4 bottles)	\$3,117.74	Approved — in transit
8	Clesen's	Rainbird irrigation system diagnosis and repair — 20 hrs service + 7 hrs travel	\$2,795.00	Approved — awaiting funding release and NAVFAC water line connection
9	R&R Products	Bedknives Micro Cut (×6), hydraulic oil (5 gal), tires (×4), starter motor	\$1,144.65	Approved — in transit
10	NAPA	Fuel line hose for gas equipment (50 ft)	\$274.50	Approved — in transit
		Total Approved/Pending	\$14,567.05	

Grand Total — All Purchase Requests: \$24,971.73

SECTION 7 — THE PLAN

Phase 1 — Immediate Actions (Now through Month 3)

Resolve the NAVFAC water line connection.

This is the single most important near-term action and it sits outside the superintendent's control. NAVFAC has partially restored water flow but the missing pipe section connecting the pump houses to the underground irrigation distribution line has not been installed. Until this is resolved, the approved irrigation repair vendor cannot fully execute the work and the course cannot be properly watered. Leadership needs to escalate this with NAVFAC directly.

Release irrigation repair funding and schedule Clesen's.

PR#18 (\$2,795.00) is approved. Once the NAVFAC water line issue is addressed, this funding needs to be released immediately so Clesen's can schedule on-site service for the Rainbird satellite communication repair. Every week this sits is another week the course operates without irrigation.

Grub treatment — Holes 3, 6, 8, 10, 15, 18.

Quicksilver herbicide and starter fertilizer are approved and on order (PR#17). Once received, applications begin immediately. Spring is the most effective treatment window. Delay moves this problem into summer when treatment efficacy decreases.

Begin moss treatment on back nine greens.

Quicksilver applications begin as soon as PR#17 arrives. This starts the moss elimination process ahead of the fall renovation. The greens wheelie sprayer (PR#16) provides the precision application capability needed for chemical work at the green level.

Execute mower rebuild once Spartan Turf parts arrive.

PR#15 (reel assemblies, bedknives, roller kits) is approved and in transit. When it arrives, the mechanic rebuilds the greens mowers. This restores in-house cutting capability and ends the dependence on the rental tractor, which is a short-term fix at \$4,738.66 per 28 days.

Cart path crack fill and sealing.

This is in-house work. The wheelie sprayer from PR#16 can be used for the sealing application. Crack filler and sealer materials need to be procured. No contractor required. This is visible, patron-facing work that can be done on a rolling basis as crew schedule allows.

Phase 2 — Agronomic Recovery (Months 3–12)

Tee box aeration and overseeding — all 16 affected holes.

Target window: September and October. Kentucky Bluegrass seed has already been received (PR#9). Aeration breaks compaction, overseeding restores density. Recovery visible by the following spring. Aerifier rental or procurement needs to be budgeted now so it is available in September.

Fairway thin turf and bare spot recovery.

Same window, same seed stock. Once irrigation is running, water management supports establishment. Fairway aeration and overseeding in fall produces results by spring.

Back nine greens renovation — bentgrass seeding.

Target: late August through early September. Bentgrass seed is on hand (PR#9). Starter fertilizer and green sand/peat mix are on hand. The renovation execution requires moss elimination (in progress), drainage correction, core aeration and material removal, and seeding. Back nine closes for the renovation. Front nine continues operation at adjusted fees. Bentgrass seeded in the late summer/early fall window in the Great Lakes climate will germinate within 10–14 days, establish through fall, and be fully playable the following spring.

Drainage correction — Holes 7, 14, and 17.

These are documented issues. A formal assessment needs to determine scope and cost. These should be addressed in coordination with the greens renovation work since drainage is the root cause of the moss problem on the back nine.

Driving range net installation.

The net is on property. A work order needs to be submitted to have it installed. Once up, the range operates with full safety coverage and can be properly monetized.

Phase 3 — Operational Excellence and Revenue Growth (Months 6–18)**Staffing resolution — laborer positions.**

This requires action above the superintendent level. The four open laborer positions represent 50% of authorized strength. Options that need to be evaluated: a NAF wage review and adjustment to bring the pay rate to market, temporary contractor labor while a permanent solution is pursued, or inter-agency labor support. Without additional bodies, the maintenance backlog documented in this plan cannot be cleared and future improvements will degrade faster than they are made.

Diesel mechanic capability.

Major diesel equipment repairs currently require outside vendor coordination which is slow and expensive. Either a qualified diesel mechanic needs to be added to the team or a standing service contract with a qualified vendor needs to be established so diesel equipment does not sit dead waiting on a quote.

Equipment disposal — 22 items.

Formal disposal proceedings should be initiated on all 22 items. This clears the inventory, removes the administrative burden of tracking unusable assets, and creates an accurate picture of what the department

actually has.

Equipment replacement capital request.

Once disposals are processed, a multi-year replacement schedule needs to be submitted as a capital request. Priority items: a reliable mowing fleet for fairways and tees, an irrigation diagnostic kit, and a utility vehicle for the maintenance crew.

Tournament and event calendar.

There is no structured event calendar at Veterans Memorial Golf Course. NAS Great Lakes has one of the largest installation populations in the Navy. Command golf days, branch birthday tournaments (Navy birthday in October, Marine Corps birthday in November), charity scrambles, and seasonal member events are all revenue opportunities that are currently not being captured. A 12-month calendar marketed through command networks, the base newspaper, and digital signage is a direct revenue line with low overhead cost.

Membership program redesign.

The current membership structure has not been actively reviewed or marketed. A redesigned program with tiered pricing — active duty, retiree, family, junior — benchmarked against area courses and marketed through Family Readiness Officers and the welcome center represents untapped recurring revenue.

Driving range revenue program.

Structured bucket pricing, defined operating hours, and potential lesson programming once the net is installed and the range is operating properly.

SECTION 8 — WHAT LEADERSHIP NEEDS TO DO

The following items require action at the leadership level. They cannot be resolved by the superintendent alone.

Action Item	Why It Matters	Urgency
Escalate NAVFAC water line pipe connection	Irrigation repair cannot fully execute without it	Immediate
Release PR#18 funding — irrigation repair (\$2,795)	Vendor (Clesen's) is ready; every week delayed is a week without water	Immediate
Authorize NAF wage review for laborer positions	4 of 8 authorized positions are vacant; course cannot be maintained at standard	Near-term
Initiate disposal process for 22 identified assets	Clears inventory; reflects accurate departmental capability	Near-term

Action Item	Why It Matters	Urgency
Approve aerifier rental/procurement budget for fall	September window for tee and fairway aeration — must be ready	60 days
Capital request — equipment replacement schedule	Sustainable mowing capability requires owned equipment, not perpetual rentals	Near-term
Back nine greens renovation capital authorization	Drainage correction and seeding inputs beyond current PR budget	90 days
Leadership engagement — quarterly status briefings	Course-to-revenue connection is not currently visible to leadership	Ongoing

SECTION 9 — REVENUE AND FINANCIAL PICTURE

Veterans Memorial Golf Course is currently generating in the \$100,000–\$300,000 annual revenue range against its potential of \$400,000–\$600,000+. The gap exists because the course is not in a condition where patrons are willing to pay competitive rates.

The cart fleet has 36 carts that can reliably be put in patron hands on a given day. That is the one area of the operation that functions at capacity. Everything else — greens quality, tee conditions, fairway appearance, range operation — is limiting return play and word-of-mouth.

The arguments for continued investment are direct:

- The rental tractor alone costs \$4,738.66 per 28 days to substitute for equipment that should be owned and operational. Repairing the mowing fleet is cheaper than renting indefinitely.
- The seed, fertilizer, and agronomic inputs needed to recover the tees, fairways, and greens are already purchased or in transit. The biggest cost in the recovery program has already been authorized.
- The irrigation repair is \$2,795. One week of additional rounds from a course that patrons want to play again covers that cost.
- The installation population at NAS Great Lakes is one of the largest in the Navy. This course does not have a demand problem. It has a product problem. Fix the product, and the demand is already there.

SECTION 10 — TIMELINE

Window	Action
Now	Escalate NAVFAC water line pipe connection
Now	Release irrigation repair funding (PR#18) — schedule Clesen's

Window	Action
Now	Begin grub treatment upon PR#17 arrival
Now	Begin moss treatment on back nine greens upon PR#17 arrival
Weeks 1–4	Rebuild greens mowers upon Spartan Turf parts arrival (PR#15)
Weeks 1–4	Submit work order for driving range net installation
Weeks 2–6	Cart path crack fill and sealing (in-house, rolling schedule)
Months 1–3	Initiate disposal proceedings on 22 flagged assets
Months 2–4	Range revenue program launched once net is installed
Months 2–4	Tournament calendar developed; membership redesign initiated
Months 3–6	Turf responds to restored irrigation; visible course-wide improvement
Month 4	Submit aerifier procurement/rental request for fall window
Month 4	Submit equipment replacement capital request
Months 4–6	Staffing wage review — leadership-level action required
Months 6–8	Back nine greens prep — additional drainage work, moss follow-up
Month 8–9	Back nine closes; bentgrass renovation seeded (late Aug/early Sept)
Month 9–10	Tee box and fairway aerification and overseeding (all 16 holes)
Month 10–14	Bentgrass establishment on back nine greens
Month 14–18	Back nine reopens — full 18-hole experience restored

SECTION 11 — PLANNED COURSE AMENITY AND PATRON EXPERIENCE IMPROVEMENTS

The following improvements address the visible, on-course elements that patrons interact with every round. These are separate from the agronomic and infrastructure work but matter just as much to the patron experience. A course that plays well and looks cared for generates repeat business. Right now several of these items are either missing, damaged, or have never been properly deployed.

Tee Markers

The course has a set of tee markers but they need significant refurbishment. The plan is to clean, stain, repaint, and reinstall spikes on the existing set through a formal work order. Several markers have broken spikes or are otherwise damaged beyond refurbishment and will need to be replaced outright. A purchase request for

replacement units on the damaged markers will be submitted once the full count is confirmed. The work order for the refurbishment of the existing set is a near-term action item.

Divot Mix Stations

Divot mix stations need to be installed at the par 3 tees across the course and at one specific par 4 where the majority of patrons use irons off the tee. A refill station will also be placed at the clubhouse for easy restocking. Sand and seed divot mix has already been received (PR#9 — Green Sand/Peat Mix, 2,000 lb tote on hand). The boxes themselves need to be procured and installed. This is a low-cost, high-visibility improvement that experienced golfers expect on a maintained course.

Tee Signs

The tee signs that display hole number, par, and yardage are set in ground-level concrete bases. Several of those bases are heaving and the signs are coming up out of the ground. The plan is to remove the deteriorated concrete bases, pour new concrete, and re-anchor each sign properly. Several signs also need to be repainted. The 18 aluminum tee signs are listed in the FY26 asset inventory (asset #17307006, value \$10,007) and are currently unverified — their exact condition will be confirmed during that process. This work can be done in-house with materials.

Water Stations

The course has water stations positioned at key locations but several are in disrepair — paint is peeling and a number of stations are missing legs, making them unusable. The plan is to repair the legs on the damaged units, repaint the entire set, and return all stations to service. Once operational, the stations will hold water coolers or jugs for patron hydration throughout the round. No replacement units need to be purchased if the repairs are completed.

Benches

There are currently no benches on the course. Patrons with mobility limitations and groups waiting on slow holes have nowhere to sit. Benches at tee boxes — particularly on the par 3s and at any tees where patron wait times occur — are a basic amenity that communicates the course cares about the experience. A procurement request for a set of course benches needs to be submitted.

Cart Traffic Control — Rope, Stakes, and Signage

The course has rope and stakes as well as cart directional signs, but none of it has been deployed. Getting this out on the course is an immediate action item that requires labor, not budget. Rope and stakes will redirect carts away from sensitive low areas and off the turf surrounding the greens. Cart path signs will show patrons where to go, which reduces turf damage in transition areas and protects the agronomic recovery work being done on the tees and fairways.

Yardage / Distance Markers

The 150-yard and other distance markers exist on the course but are not in the correct positions on several holes and are faded and in need of repainting. Correcting marker placement and repainting is in-house work that can be done as the crew schedule allows. Accurate yardage information is a basic expectation for any golfer.

Hazard Stakes and Out-of-Bounds Markers

No white out-of-bounds stakes or hazard stakes (red/yellow) have been located on the course. Whether the existing inventory was lost, removed, or never replaced is not yet known. A complete set of OB stakes and hazard stakes needs to be procured and installed on all applicable holes. This is a rules-of-golf requirement — patrons cannot properly apply rules without defined boundaries and hazard markings.

Directional Tee-to-Green Signage

Signs directing patrons from the green to the next tee may exist somewhere on the property but have not been located. A full survey of what is on hand and what is missing needs to be completed. Any gaps will be filled through procurement. A course this size requires clear navigation signage, particularly for patrons who are new to the course.

Custom Navy / Veterans Flags

Rather than standard commercial pin flags, the plan is to have a custom set of flags designed to honor Naval Station Great Lakes and the veterans who have served here. The flags would incorporate the NAS Great Lakes insignia or a veterans-focused design. This is the kind of detail that distinguishes a military installation course from a generic public facility. It connects the course to its mission and its patron base in a tangible, visible way, and it is the kind of thing people photograph and share. A custom flag set will be a line item in the next procurement cycle.

Wooden Bridges

Three wooden bridges are listed in the FY26 asset inventory (asset numbers 11005212, 11005213, 11005214, values \$1,777 / \$1,777 / \$1,383 respectively — all currently unverified). These bridges cross water and drainage areas on the course and their structural condition has not been confirmed. A physical inspection of all three needs to be completed. Any bridges with structural deficiencies represent both a safety liability and a patron experience problem. Repair or replacement will be added to the capital improvement request once inspection results are in hand.

Course Yardage Book / Patron Guide

Veterans Memorial Golf Course does not have a current yardage book or course guide. A yardage book — even a simple printed version — is something patrons at every level of play expect. It also serves as a marketing tool: patrons keep them, share them, and use them to plan return visits. Creating one is a low-cost

project that significantly upgrades the perceived quality of the experience. This will be developed and produced as part of the Phase 3 patron experience improvements.

SECTION 12 — ADDITIONAL OPPORTUNITIES

Items worth discussing that are not part of the core operational plan:

- **Installation-wide awareness campaign.** A substantial portion of eligible patrons at NAS Great Lakes — active duty, dependents, retirees — do not know Veterans Memorial Golf Course exists or is accessible to them. A targeted communication effort through base channels (newspaper, digital signage, command POCs) costs nearly nothing and could move rounds within weeks.
 - **Active duty season pass.** A discounted annual pass marketed to E1–E6 builds a new generation of golfers on the installation and generates recurring revenue from a population that is often looking for affordable recreation options.
 - **Command and unit golf events.** NAS Great Lakes trains tens of thousands of sailors per year. The permanent party command structure represents a natural audience for organized golf events. Command golf days do not require a formal tournament infrastructure — they can start as simple scheduled tee times marketed to commands directly.
 - **Golf as a fitness and wellness activity.** Walking 18 holes is a significant physical activity. Marketing Willow Glen through the fitness and wellness channels on base reaches sailors and Marines who are physically active but do not yet identify as golfers.
 - **Volunteer maintenance support.** Units seeking community service hours can provide meaningful labor support during intensive cleanup and renovation periods — debris clearing, rough cleanup, path repair. This supplements a thin crew without payroll cost.
 - **Quarterly leadership briefings with data.** Before-and-after condition data, revenue comparisons, rounds played, and purchase request progress presented quarterly keeps leadership connected to what is actually happening on the ground. The recovery documented in this plan deserves to be tracked and reported, not assumed.
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SECTION 13 — CLOSING

Six weeks in. Daily maintenance routines are restructured. Ten purchase requests totaling nearly \$25,000 have been submitted, approved, and partially received. The mowing equipment rebuild is in motion. The seed, fertilizer, and moss treatment for the fall recovery are on hand or in transit. The irrigation vendor is identified and the proposal is approved.

The work is moving. What is not moving is the NAVFAC water line connection and the funding release for the irrigation repair. Those two items sit outside my control and are the most time-sensitive things in this plan. Every week without water is another week the course cannot recover.

Veterans Memorial Golf Course has been a part of Naval Station Great Lakes for a long time. The installation it serves is the largest in the Navy. The patron base is here. The bones of the course are solid. What has been missing is the investment, the staffing, and the leadership attention required to make it what it should be.

I am doing the work. I need leadership to support it.

Prepared by Tyson Bruce, Golf Course Superintendent — May 2026

All issue data sourced from the Veterans Memorial Golf Course management system. All purchase request figures sourced from the MWR procurement system with vendor quotes on file. FY26 asset data sourced from the active inventory. Full records available upon request.